

Information Asymmetry and Hidden Drivers of Unexpected Stock Moves

Executive summary

What feels “irrational” from a technical-trading perspective is often not irrational at all. In modern U.S. equities, the marginal price is set by whichever flow is most urgent and best informed at that moment, not by your estimate of the company’s quality. A “solid” stock can drop because a large holder is de-risking, dealers are selling stock to hedge options exposure, a lock-up or secondary offering changes float expectations, a macro print tightens financial conditions, or liquidity briefly disappears. A “weak” stock can rise because of short covering, gamma squeezes, social-media coordination, event-driven positioning, ETF or sector rotation, or a public filing that changes the expected payoff distribution even if current fundamentals still look poor. The core lesson is that price is a clearing mechanism for information, inventory, and liquidity—not a moral scorecard on business quality. ¹

For a retail investor, the most valuable shift is from asking “Why did this move violate my chart?” to asking “Which hidden mechanism was most likely setting the marginal price?” In practice, the main hidden drivers cluster into a finite set: information asymmetry and adverse selection; institutional order flow and rebalancing; dark or off-exchange trading and hidden liquidity; algorithmic routing and market microstructure; options and derivatives hedging; short-interest dynamics and squeezes; news, rumors, and social-media cascades; macro and rates shocks; regulatory filings; earnings and guidance surprises; and capital-structure mechanics around M&A, SPACs, IPOs, secondaries, lock-ups, and warrants. Once you monitor those categories systematically, many “mystery” moves become interpretable, even if they are never fully predictable. ²

The bad news is that retail investors generally cannot be truly “ahead” of institutions that pay for direct feeds, premium news, expert networks, sell-side research, alternative data, and execution analytics. The good news is that you can narrow the gap materially by focusing on the highest signal-to-noise public and low-cost tools: fast news, SEC filing alerts, exchange depth, options-flow and dealer-positioning tools, premarket and after-hours monitoring, macro calendars, insider transactions, short-interest and borrow context, and social-sentiment dashboards. The realistic objective is not omniscience. It is faster diagnosis, fewer confused trades, and better risk management when price action is being driven by something other than the chart pattern you were studying. ³

Why price moves look irrational from a technical lens

A useful starting point is market microstructure rather than valuation. The SEC’s 2021 staff report explains that off-exchange market makers actively segment order flow because some traders are more informed or more predictive than others. Market makers try to avoid adverse selection, and the bid-ask spread compensates them for the risk that prices move against them after they fill an order. The same report also notes that large parent orders are often broken into many child orders through smart routers, which means

an apparently small print can still be part of a much larger institutional program. In other words, the visible tape is often only the surface expression of a much larger inventory-transfer process. 4

That same SEC report is also a good antidote to the idea that Level II or the NBBO shows “the market.” It explicitly notes that NBBO-based execution quality does not include many better-priced odd lots or non-displayed orders, and that a significant amount of activity occurs inside the NBBO. This is one reason technical traders can feel as though price “teleported” through a level or reacted to invisible supply and demand: some of that supply and demand is, in fact, non-displayed. Retail screens show enough to orient you, but not enough to reveal the whole book. 4

Dark and off-exchange trading add another layer of opacity. FINRA’s OTC Transparency data shows that ATS and non-ATS off-exchange volume is published only with delays—two weeks for Tier 1 NMS names and four weeks for other NMS and OTC names—and the published data are aggregate summaries, not a real-time map of hidden liquidity. That means public “dark pool” analytics used by retail traders are usually proxies built from trade-reporting facility prints, block-trade heuristics, and historical aggregation rather than true real-time visibility into institutional intent. Those tools can still be useful, but they are not x-ray vision. 5

Options hedging is another frequent source of “non-fundamental” moves. Cboe-linked research on ODTE index options finds that when options market makers hold negative gamma and delta hedge dynamically, their rebalancing trades can amplify underlying moves; in positive gamma, the opposite can happen and moves can be dampened. The paper estimates a measurable impact of aggregate market-maker gamma on near-term volatility. For single names, the same intuition applies around heavily concentrated strike open interest, short-dated call buying, and rapid changes in dealer delta. If you trade charts while ignoring dealer positioning, you are effectively ignoring one of the modern market’s largest mechanical flows. 6

Short squeezes and float mechanics explain many of the seemingly upside-down rallies in weak businesses. SEC and FINRA materials make clear that short interest data are only reported twice monthly, which means the market often reacts to the latent possibility of a squeeze before public short data fully catch up. GameStop’s own SEC filing warns that if short exposure exceeds the number of shares available for purchase or borrowing, short-covering can dramatically increase the stock price irrespective of operating performance. That is why “weak” can rise violently: price may be clearing a positioning imbalance, not expressing improved fundamentals. 7

Event filings matter more than many chart-based traders realize. Form 8-K is the SEC’s “current report” for major corporate events and is generally due within four business days, though some Regulation FD situations can require faster disclosure. Form 4 insider transactions are generally due within two business days. Initial Schedule 13D filings for crossing 5% beneficial ownership are now subject to a five-business-day deadline, while Form 13F is due within 45 days after quarter-end. These filings are not always predictive in the sense of giving you first-mover advantage. But they are often the quickest official explanation for price behavior you would otherwise misread as “random.” 8

Macro shocks and liquidity conditions can overwhelm single-name quality. The Federal Reserve publishes its FOMC calendar, the Bureau of Labor Statistics publishes exact release dates for CPI and jobs data, and Treasury publishes refunding and auction schedules. Those official event times matter because they regularly change discount rates, index futures, and sector correlations in ways that dominate stock-specific setups. A technically perfect chart can fail instantly if the market reprices rates, inflation, or growth. 9

The table below is the shortest practical summary of the main hidden drivers.

Hidden driver	What it does to price	Why it confuses technical traders	What retail can actually monitor
Informed or better-predictive flow	Market makers widen or skew pricing against adverse selection	The chart shows the effect, not the reason	Fast news, SEC filings, unusual price/volume, routing context under Rule 606. ¹⁰
Hidden and off-exchange liquidity	Large interest may not appear on lit books	Support/resistance can look fake or porous	FINRA ATS/OTC transparency, block-print tools, lit depth feeds. ¹¹
Dealer hedging and gamma	Price can be mechanically accelerated or pinned around strikes	Indicators interpret flow as “momentum” or “reversal” after the fact	Options flow, open interest, IV, dealer-positioning tools. ¹²
Short squeeze and float stress	Weak companies can rip on forced covering	Fundamentals look bad, but positioning is worse	Short interest, float, borrow context, lock-ups, secondaries. ¹³
Regulatory filings and event disclosures	New information changes payoff distribution fast	Price often moves before most chart patterns are “confirmed”	8-K, 4, 13D, S-4, Schedule TO, 13F, prospectus supplements. ¹⁴
Macro and liquidity shocks	Single-name setups get overridden by rates and index flows	The stock acts like the market, not itself	FOMC, CPI, payrolls, Treasury calendar, halts/ LULD. ¹⁵

Professional data sources and what they cost

Professionals do not rely on one “magic” source. They stack multiple data classes: direct exchange depth, high-speed news, filings intelligence, options analytics, ownership and short-interest tools, and alternative data. For a retail investor, the right question is not “What do institutions use?” but “Which institutional-style sources have the best marginal value per dollar for my process?” The answer is usually to start with a small number of fast, interpretable products rather than buying a pseudo-institutional dashboard that you will not fully exploit. ¹⁶

Published-price tools with strong practical value

Priority	Tool or feed	What pros use it for	Public price signal	Main strengths	Main weaknesses	Source
Very high	Nasdaq TotalView	Full displayed depth-of-book for Nasdaq, NYSE, and regional issues	Non-professional \$15/month ; professional \$84/month effective Jan. 2026	True lit-book depth; useful for liquidity, spoof-prone areas, and intraday supply/demand	Still misses hidden liquidity; depth alone does not explain catalyst	17
Very high	NYSE OpenBook Ultra / ArcaBook	Event-by-event depth and order-book monitoring	NYSE American OpenBook non-pro \$1/device ; ArcaBook non-pro \$10/device in ICE pricing guide	Helpful for event-based depth and ETF-heavy names on Arca	Exchange-specific; retail access depends on broker/platform	18
Very high	Benzinga Pro	Fast news, scanner, calendar, squawk	Essential plan about \$197/month ; vendor notes annual savings	Real-time news plus scanner/calendar in one place; practical for active retail use	Still not a terminal; quality depends on habits and filters	19
Very high	Unusual Whales	Options flow, dark-pool-style block monitoring, alerts	Plans from about \$48/month ; API from \$150/month	Strong retail options-flow workflow; accessible price point	Interpretation risk is high; many “sweeps” are hedges, rolls, or spreads	20
High	SpotGamma	Dealer positioning, key volatility levels, flow analysis	Essential \$99/month ; Alpha \$299/month ; annual discounts available	Best for understanding whether options may be damping or amplifying moves	Model-driven; easier to misuse on single names without options context	21

Priority	Tool or feed	What pros use it for	Public price signal	Main strengths	Main weaknesses	Source
High	FlowAlgo	Unusual options activity and dark-pool/block context	Roughly \$149/month after trial; annual plans lower	Retail-friendly live options tape interpretation	Similar ambiguity problem: not every big print is “smart money”	22
High	Cboe LiveVol Core / Pro	Professional options chain analysis, vol surface, time-and-sales	Core \$105/month ; Pro starts \$350/month , excluding data fees	Exchange-linked options analytics; more institutional feel	Complexity; market-data fees may add meaningfully	23
High	Koyfin	Multi-asset research, filings, transcripts, premium news	Plus \$39/month ; Premium \$79/month	Excellent generalized research and monitoring value	Less specialized for intraday flow than options/news products	24
Medium	Quiver Quantitative	Insider trading, institutional trading, social trends, government and alt-style datasets	Premium about \$25/month	Cheap way to centralize nontraditional retail-friendly signals	Data breadth can exceed data depth; some signals are noisy or delayed	25
Medium	The Fly	Real-time market news and street research headlines	Via IBKR: newsfeed free trial, \$30/month without API; API higher	Good for research-note headlines and real-time developments	Strength is speed and summarized research, not deep ownership or flow	26

Enterprise and quote-only products professionals rely on

Priority	Platform	Typical institutional use	Public pricing status	Why it matters	Practical retail takeaway	Source
Very high	Bloomberg Terminal	Cross-asset news, data, analytics, messaging, execution, research	Bloomberg does not publish site pricing; widely reported around just under \$32,000/year for one terminal as of 2025	Still the institutional default because it integrates data, news, and workflow	Retail generally should not buy it; emulate the workflow, not the logo	27
Very high	LSEG Workspace	Reuters news, data, analytics, cross-asset monitoring	Quote-only / speak to specialist	Serious institutional competitor to Bloomberg, especially for news + data workflows	Worth knowing because Reuters headlines often hit Workspace first	28
Very high	FactSet	Research, portfolio analytics, estimates, models	Quote-only publicly; official site does not publish prices	Deep institutional research stack; common on fundamental desks	Retail should seek cheaper substitutes unless doing professional-level work	29
Very high	AlphaSense	Search across filings, transcripts, expert calls, broker research, news	Officially quote-only, annual subscriptions	Particularly strong for research search and “what changed?” workflows	Valuable conceptually even if you use cheaper substitutes like Koyfin + The Fly + EDGAR	30

Priority	Platform	Typical institutional use	Public pricing status	Why it matters	Practical retail takeaway	Source
High	YipitData	Alternative data on consumer, transaction, and company KPIs	Quote-only / enterprise	Used to anticipate intra-quarter performance before earnings	Retail can imitate the mindset, but not usually the full dataset	31
High	M Science	Data-driven research and alternative data	Quote-only / enterprise	Institutional alt-data research on sectors and companies	Good reminder that many pros are trading “shadow earnings” before the print	32
High	Similarweb Stock Intelligence	Web and app traffic as leading indicators	Quote-only / contact us	Digital-demand signal for internet and platform names	Retail can sometimes get partial analogs through public web/app trend tools, but not full coverage	33
High	VandaTrack	Daily and intraday retail-flow analytics	Quote-only / request access	Excellent for identifying where retail demand is becoming a price driver	Retail can monitor free sentiment dashboards, but not this full flow feed	34

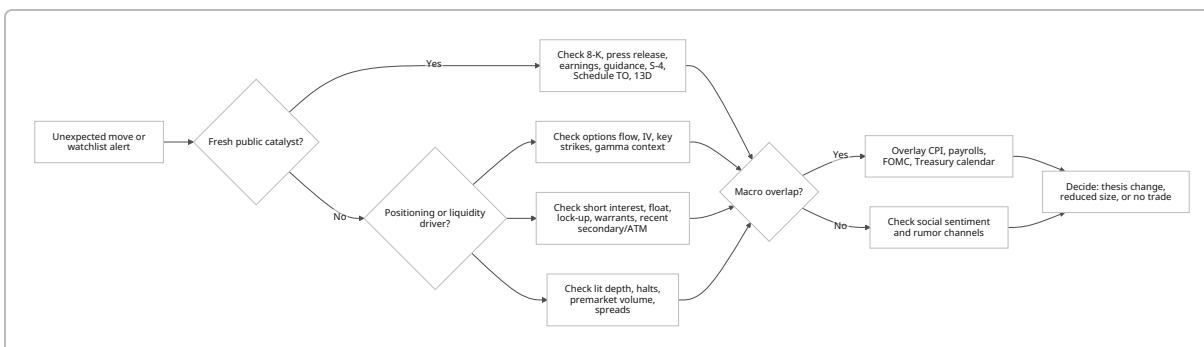
The professional reality is that the most defensible edge comes from combining fast official information with proprietary context, not from staring harder at a single chart. If your budget is limited, the best “institutional” retail stack is usually one fast news tool, one options/flow tool, one research/filings tool, and disciplined use of free official sources. 35

A retail workflow that actually improves signal quality

A practical retail workflow should be organized by latency. Some signals are immediate but noisy, like options sweeps or social chatter. Some are slow but high quality, like 13F or FINRA ATS data. The goal is to use the fast layer for triage and the slower layer for interpretation. That prevents the classic mistake of

acting on “smart money” screenshots with no understanding of whether the flow is opening, closing, hedging, rolling, or simply liquidity taking. ³⁶

The core workflow below is intentionally implementable. It assumes you want earlier signals, but also want to avoid paying for a full institutional stack.



The official, low-cost, and retail-accessible pieces of that workflow are summarized here.

Signal class	Best low-cost or free source	Timing	What it is good for	Main caveat	Source
Material company event	SEC EDGAR / Form 8-K	Generally within 4 business days , sometimes earlier	Acquisitions, financing, guidance, management changes, major agreements	Not always first, but often the official explanation	³⁷
Insider buying/selling	SEC Forms 3/4/5	Form 4 generally within 2 business days	Detecting insider conviction or distribution	Many trades are routine or preplanned	³⁸
New activist or 5% holder	Schedule 13D	Initial filing within 5 business days after crossing 5%	Identifies stake-building and control intent	Still delayed relative to first acquisition	³⁹
Institutional holdings	Form 13F	45 days after quarter-end	Slow-moving ownership mapping	Too stale for short-term timing	⁴⁰
Short positioning	FINRA/Nasdaq/ NYSE short interest	Reported twice monthly	Squeeze risk, days-to-cover context	Delayed; not live borrow pressure	⁴¹

Signal class	Best low-cost or free source	Timing	What it is good for	Main caveat	Source
Off-exchange / ATS activity	FINRA OTC Transparency / ATS data	2-4 week delay depending on security tier	Validate whether a name is heavily active off exchange	Diagnostic, not predictive intraday	5
Lit depth and tape	Nasdaq TotalView / NYSE OpenBook / broker L2	Real time	Liquidity, depth, absorption, spoof-prone zones	Hidden liquidity still exists	42
Volatility and strike mechanics	SpotGamma, LiveVol, Unusual Whales, FlowAlgo	Real time to intraday	Dealer hedging, crowding around strikes, unusual options activity	Flow can be hedge-related and misleading	43
Fast news and squawk	Benzinga Pro, The Fly, Reuters, broker news feeds	Real time	The fastest public-ish explanation for a move	Headlines still need verification	44
Social and retail attention	Stocktwits, ApeWisdom, Quiver, VandaTrack	Minutes to intraday	Detect meme-style setup risk	Very noisy; sentiment is not valuation	45
Premarket / after-hours	Nasdaq market-activity pages and broker extended hours	4:00-9:30 a.m. ET and 4:00-8:00 p.m. ET	Early reaction to filings, earnings, or macro	Lower liquidity and wider spreads distort signal	46
Macro calendar	Fed, BLS, Treasury official calendars	Scheduled in advance	Protect against "good stock, bad macro tape" mistakes	Many traders still underestimate auction/ refunding impact	47
Volatility halts	Nasdaq/NYSE halt pages, LULD references	Real time	Confirms genuine disorderly trading or news pending	Halts are a symptom, not a thesis	48

A realistic retail stack by budget looks like this. At roughly **\$0-\$75/month**, use free official sources plus Quiver or one low-cost sentiment/options tool. At **\$75-\$250/month**, add a fast news product and a dedicated options/gamma tool. Above that, the best incremental spend is usually depth data or a better options platform, not a pseudo-terminal that duplicates features you are not using well. 49

Case studies

SpaceX-related example

A clean recent SpaceX-related example is the sector reaction around the company's June 2026 public-market debut. Reuters reported that SpaceX's IPO was followed by sharp weakness in other public "space" names including Rocket Lab, Planet Labs, Intuitive Machines, and AST SpaceMobile, even though there had been no equivalent deterioration in those companies' own immediate fundamentals. Reuters and other industry commentary attributed part of the move to sector rebalancing and a scramble by investors to make room for the newly public bellwether, while a later Reuters report highlighted that the launch of listed options in SpaceX itself was a significant driver of continued price action in the days after the debut. The important lesson is that a public event in one flagship company can mechanically re-anchor valuation, liquidity, and positioning across a whole theme basket. If you only looked at ASTS or RKLK charts, the move could look "unfair"; if you looked at sector capital rotation and options mechanics, it looked much more explainable.

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GameStop and the return of social-plus-options reflexivity

GameStop's 2024 rally is a textbook case of non-obvious flow overwhelming fundamentals. Reuters documented the stock's surge after the return of Keith Gill's "Roaring Kitty" persona on social media, followed by renewed large disclosed call-option exposure and unusually heavy trading in short-dated contracts. GameStop then used the volatility to sell stock through at-the-market programs, raising substantial cash, while its SEC disclosure itself warned that short squeezes and media-driven buying could cause price moves unrelated or disproportionate to operating performance. This was not fundamentally random. It was a reflexive loop among social attention, options leverage, short-covering risk, volatility, and corporate issuance. A chart alone would not tell you that. The options tape, short-interest context, and SEC filings would.

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Trump Media and SPAC-float mechanics

Trump Media's 2024 trading around its de-SPAC and later lock-up dynamics is a strong example of how capital-structure details can dominate price. Reuters chronicled the stock's extraordinary volatility after the March 2024 debut through the Digital World SPAC merger, its sharp drop after filings indicated potential sale of a much larger share pool, and later weakness as the insider lock-up approached and expired. The company's SEC filing explicitly defined the lock-up period and the conditions under which it could end. In practice, that meant traders were repricing not the media business alone, but the expected future supply of stock, warrant and registration mechanics, and the effect of a relatively constrained float. This is exactly the category of move that many retail traders misread as "manipulation" when it is often just cap-table mechanics becoming newly salient.

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Wendy's and the modern meme-stock template

A more recent example is Wendy's in June 2026. Reuters reported that the shares surged more than 28% intraday in a meme-like rally driven by retail participation, multiple volatility halts, and high short interest—Reuters cited short interest at 34% of free float and notable retail buying based on Vanda Research metrics. From a purely fundamental lens, the move made little sense relative to the company's recent operating struggles. From a positioning lens, it made perfect sense: high short interest, thin confidence in

fundamentals, and a sudden burst of social attention created the conditions for squeeze-like behavior. This is an important reminder that “weak” stocks can rise hardest precisely because they are weak, crowded, and narratively combustible. ⁵³

Legal, ethical, and practical limits

There is a hard line between being observant and trying to trade on material nonpublic information. The SEC defines illegal insider trading as buying or selling on the basis of material nonpublic information in breach of a duty of trust or confidence. The SEC also expects advisers using alternative data to maintain policies and due diligence designed to prevent misuse of MNPI. For a retail investor, the safe rule is simple: use public information, legitimate analytics, and lawful inference. Do not seek or act on confidential corporate information, “inside” chat-room claims, or anything that appears selectively disclosed. ⁵⁴

Social media deserves special caution. The SEC and investor-protection authorities have repeatedly warned that social media can be used to spread false or misleading stock rumors and pump-and-dump schemes. That warning matters even when the underlying move is real. A stock can legitimately squeeze while the surrounding online narrative is full of fabricated “reasons” or fake screenshots. Retail investors should treat social feeds as an early-smoke detector, not evidence. Confirmation should come from filings, reputable news, official calendars, and observable market structure. ⁵⁵

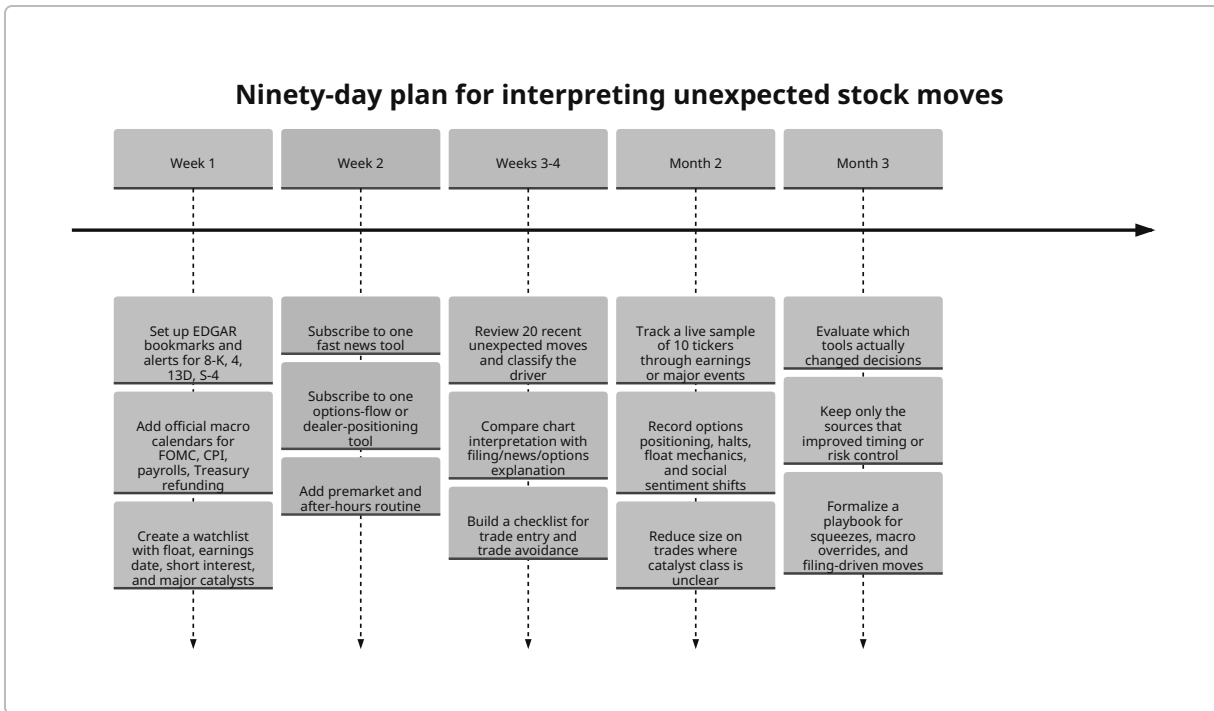
Realistic expectations also matter. Many professional sources are delayed, incomplete, or purpose-built for institutions. Form 13F is backward-looking by design. Short-interest reports are semi-monthly, not live. FINRA ATS and OTC transparency are delayed. Even “real-time” options flow is ambiguous because you usually do not know whether a trade is opening, closing, hedging, or part of a larger spread without more context. The retail edge, therefore, is usually not predicting every move in advance. It is recognizing the likely driver faster, avoiding false certainty, and sizing risk accordingly. ⁵⁶

Open questions and limitations remain. Publicly available cost data for some enterprise products are incomplete because vendors such as FactSet, LSEG Workspace, AlphaSense, YipitData, M Science, Similarweb, and VandaTrack generally use quote-only pricing rather than publishing flat fees. Also, many “dark pool” retail tools rely on proprietary classification or heuristics that cannot be fully validated from public sources. Those limitations do not make the tools useless, but they do make healthy skepticism essential. ⁵⁷

Ninety-day learning and action plan

The best next step is not to consume more indicators. It is to build a repeatable **event-diagnosis process** around your existing technical framework. Keep your charts, but add an explicit catalyst layer. Before every trade, ask: “What is the likely marginal driver here—fundamentals, macro, options, short-covering, float mechanics, or hidden liquidity?” That one question alone will improve selectivity. ⁵⁸

A practical setup for the next three months is this: use free official sources for filings, macro releases, short interest, halts, and ATS transparency; add one fast news product and one options/dealer-positioning tool; maintain a watchlist with float, short-interest, upcoming earnings, and known event dates; and review every surprising move by classifying it after the fact. Over time, the review log becomes your own playbook. ⁵⁹



The plan below is the most implementable version.

Phase	Actions	Output you should have by the end
First month	Build the information layer: EDGAR routine, macro calendar, halt pages, short-interest checks, one news feed, one options tool	A daily dashboard and a watchlist that explains <i>why</i> you are watching each ticker, not just <i>what pattern</i> it is forming
Second month	Do post-mortems on surprise moves and paper-trade the diagnosis process	A labeled journal of at least 20 moves sorted by driver class: filing, macro, squeeze, gamma, float, or liquidity
Third month	Tighten execution rules and cut tool clutter	A personal playbook, a retained tool stack, and explicit “no-trade” rules for setups likely driven by opaque flows you cannot handicap

If I were prioritizing for a retail investor with a serious but not institutional budget, I would recommend this order of operations: first, **free official sources plus disciplined routines**; second, **one fast news source**; third, **one options/dealer-positioning source**; fourth, **depth data if you trade actively enough to use it**; and only after that, higher-end research tools. The biggest gains usually come from improving diagnosis discipline, not from buying the most expensive dashboard on day one. ⁶⁰

3 19 35 44 **Pricing Offers - Benzinga Pro**

https://www.benzinga.com/pro/pricing?utm_source=chatgpt.com

5 11 **TRACE User Guide**

<https://www.finra.org/sites/default/files/OTC-transparency-data-user-guide-v4.pdf>

6 12 36 **cdn.cboe.com**

https://cdn.cboe.com/resources/education/research_publications/gammasqueezes.pdf

7 13 41 **Short Interest Reporting | FINRA.org**

https://www.finra.org/filing-reporting/regulatory-filing-systems/short-interest?utm_source=chatgpt.com

8 14 37 59 60 **Form 8-K | Investor.gov**

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary/form-8-k>

9 15 47 **The Fed - Meeting calendars and information**

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18 **OpenBook Ultra - NYSE Exchange Data**

https://www.nyse.com/market-data/real-time/openbook-ultra?utm_source=chatgpt.com

20 **Unusual Whales: Options Flow, Stock Data, Trading Tools ...**

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21 43 **What is the cost of a SpotGamma Subscription?**

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25 49 **Quiver Quantitative**

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29 **FactSet | Financial Data, Market Analytics & AI Solutions**

https://www.factset.com/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

30 Pricing

https://www.alpha-sense.com/pricing/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

31 YipitData

https://www.yipitdata.com/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

32 M Science | Data-Driven Research & Alternative Data Insights

https://mscience.com/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

33 Stock Intelligence: Stock-specific Data & Analysis

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55 Social Media and Investment Fraud – Investor Alert

https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/general-resources/news-alerts/alerts-bulletins/investor-alerts/social-media-and-investment-fraud-investor-alert?utm_source=chatgpt.com